

Student Hackathon Proposal

A student strand for Limerick IT Summit 2027, “The Automation Toolkit”, on Thursday 25 February 2027

Item	Detail
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Prepared for	The Limerick IT Summit 2027 organisers
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Status	Draft for discussion. Dates, numbers and targets marked “proposed” need the organisers’ agreement.
Companion files	Limerick_IT_Summit_2027_Hackathon_Proposal_Deck.pptx (presentation); Limerick_IT_Summit_2027_Round1_Idea_Template.pptx (participant template)

About this proposal

This proposal adds a student hackathon to Limerick IT Summit 2027. Students from universities and colleges across Ireland build practical, trustworthy automation tools for SMEs, and the winning teams show their work to summit attendees on summit day.

Facts about the summit are taken from the summit website (captured on 4 November 2026). Everything else is a proposal for the organisers to accept, change or decline.

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1. Executive summary

Limerick IT Summit 2027 takes place on Thursday 25 February 2027 at Dell Technologies, Limerick, under the theme “The Automation Toolkit”. This proposal adds a student hackathon to the summit. Teams from higher-education institutions across Ireland build automation tools for real SME problems, guided by mentors, over three rounds that end in a 24-hour Grand Finale on the weekend before the summit. The winning teams then demo their work to summit attendees and pitch on the main stage.

The hackathon supports the summit’s four goals (Community Education, SME Focused, Practical and Accessible, Charity Focused). It also takes on the technology issues of 2025–26: generative and agentic AI, ransomware against organisations and their suppliers, large cloud outages, and the energy cost of computing.

What this proposal includes

- **Three rounds:** an online idea submission (Round 1), a one-week online mentored build sprint for shortlisted teams (Round 2), and a 24-hour on-site Grand Finale on Saturday 20 and Sunday 21 February 2027.
- **11 challenge tracks** that follow the summit’s ten automation areas, plus an open track.
- **An SME Challenge Bank:** real problems submitted by local businesses through the summit’s community.
- **A summit-day showcase:** winning teams demo to attendees on 25 February, pitch on the main stage, and attendees vote for an SME Choice award.
- **The Trust Triad:** every project shows that it is secure, responsible and efficient, using a one-page Trust Card. This matches the summit’s view that automation should be introduced responsibly.
- **A declared-AI policy:** AI coding assistants are allowed, but teams must declare their use, and every member must be able to explain the code.
- **Judging that rewards quality over quantity**, with calibration, conflict-of-interest declarations and a clear appeals process.
- **Participant-friendly IP:** teams keep ownership of what they build.

Proposed size (to confirm once a finale venue is agreed)

Round 1 is open to all eligible teams. Up to **40 teams** go through to Round 2, and **20 to 25 teams (about 80 to 100 students)** reach the Grand Finale.

This is a realistic size for a first edition run mainly by volunteers, and it is the basis for the staffing estimates in this proposal.

2. The summit and how the hackathon fits

2.1 Limerick IT Summit 2027 at a glance

From the summit website, captured on 4 November 2026:

Item	Detail
Edition	Limerick IT Summit 2027, following the 2025 and 2026 summits

Item	Detail
Theme	“The Automation Toolkit”: the tools, systems and practical approaches that help organisations reduce repetitive work, improve productivity and create stronger ways of working. It is “not about replacing people”, but about where automation creates real value and how it can be introduced responsibly.
Date and venue	Thursday 25 February 2027, Dell Technologies, Limerick
Mission	Based in the Mid West, to connect Ireland’s business and technology communities while ensuring SMEs have access to the information, education and relationships they need to thrive
Audience	SME leaders and business owners; technology companies; industry professionals; founders and innovators
Goals	Community Education; SME Focused; Practical and Accessible; Charity Focused
Automation areas	Business processes and administration; artificial intelligence and intelligent assistants; sales and marketing; customer service and communications; finance and reporting; cybersecurity and compliance; websites, platforms and system integrations; data management and decision-making; workforce productivity; startup and business operations
Charity partner	Limerick Mental Health Association

The website does not mention a student programme, so the hackathon would be a new strand of the summit.

2.2 How the hackathon supports the summit’s goals

Summit goal	How the hackathon supports it
Community Education	Students learn automation, security and responsible AI through mentoring and two short workshops. SMEs see what local students can build, and students meet the Mid West business community.
SME Focused	An SME Challenge Bank of real business problems, tracks that mirror the summit’s automation areas, an SME owner on the final judging panel, and an SME Choice award voted at the summit.
Practical and Accessible	Open to every eligible student. Projects are practical tools, and teams are encouraged to publish them as open source so SMEs can try them. Accessibility is part of the Trust Triad, and a non-overnight format is available if needed.
Charity Focused	An optional community challenge from the summit’s charity partner, subject to its agreement, and a wellbeing-first finale with scheduled breaks, a quiet room and rest areas.

2.3 Timing

The summit is on a Thursday, so the Grand Finale is held on the weekend before it: **Saturday 20 and Sunday 21 February 2027**. Results are announced at the finale, and the winning teams present at the summit four days later. This gives teams time to polish their demos and lets the summit show finished work rather than work in progress.

3. Why automation needs trust now: technology and regulation, 2025–26

The summit's theme says automation should be introduced responsibly. The developments below show why, and they shape the tracks and the Trust Triad. Each point comes from the public sources in Appendix C, checked on 4 November 2026. Regulatory dates change, so they should be re-checked before participant materials are published.

Trend	What has happened	What it means for the hackathon
AI is now regulated	The EU AI Act (Regulation (EU) 2024/1689) entered into force on 1 August 2024. Prohibited practices have applied since 2 February 2025, rules for general-purpose AI models since 2 August 2025, and transparency duties (Article 50) since 2 August 2026. Under the 2026 "Digital Omnibus" amendments, obligations for stand-alone high-risk systems move to 2 December 2027 and for high-risk AI in regulated products to 2 August 2028.	Projects in Track 2 state their intended use, data sources and limits, tell users when they are dealing with AI, and avoid prohibited uses.
Ransomware against organisations and their suppliers	Ireland's health service (HSE) was hit by Conti ransomware in May 2021; an independent post-incident review was published in December 2021. In September 2025 a ransomware attack on a third-party check-in and boarding system disrupted Dublin Airport and other European airports.	Security-by-design and supplier risk feature in Track 6, the Trust Card and the overnight mini-CTF.
Cyber regulation is tightening	Ireland has not yet transposed the NIS2 Directive; the European Commission referred Ireland to the EU Court of Justice in July 2026, and the National Cyber Security Bill is still expected. The EU Cyber Resilience Act's reporting duties for actively exploited vulnerabilities and severe incidents have applied since 11 September 2026, with most other obligations from 11 December 2027.	Track 6 covers practical compliance for small firms; teams handle credentials and updates properly.
Cloud and software fragility	A faulty security-software update on 19 July 2024 affected about 8.5 million Windows devices (Microsoft's estimate). A major AWS outage in the us-east-1 region on 19–20 October 2025 was traced to a race condition in DynamoDB's automated DNS management.	Automations must fail safely. Track 7 covers reliable integrations, and judges ask about single points of failure.
The energy cost of computing	Data centres used 22% of Ireland's metered electricity in 2024, up from 5% in 2015 (CSO). Later CSO figures, reported in 2026, put the 2025 share at 23%.	"Efficient" is a Trust Triad pillar, and there is a Green Code award.
Accessibility is law	The European Accessibility Act has applied in Ireland since 28 June 2025 (S.I. No. 636 of 2023). It covers websites, apps, e-commerce and many other digital services.	Track 7 includes accessibility checks for small online shops, and every user-facing project gets a basic accessibility check.
Securing AI applications	The OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications (2025) lists prompt injection as the top risk.	A lightning workshop at the finale, and a Trust Card question for AI-based projects.

Trend	What has happened	What it means for the hackathon
Post-quantum cryptography	NIST published its first three finalised post-quantum cryptography standards (FIPS 203, 204 and 205) in August 2024.	An optional advanced challenge in Track 6.

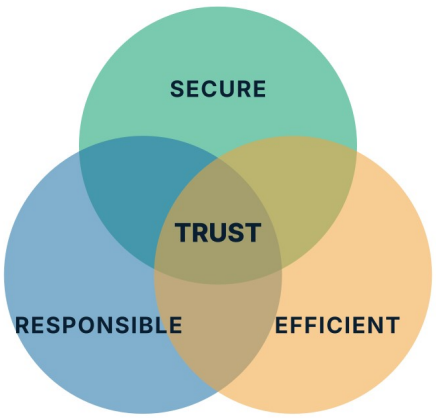
4. Hackathon concept and the Trust Triad

4.1 Hackathon at a glance

Element	Proposal
Working title	Limerick IT Summit 2027 Student Hackathon
Theme line	Build automation people can trust: secure, responsible, efficient
Who can enter	Undergraduate and postgraduate students aged 18 or over, enrolled at a higher-education institution in Ireland, from any discipline. Teams can mix institutions.
Team size	2 to 4 members. Suggested roles: frontend and user experience; backend and data; research and presentation; and team lead with integration.
Format	Hybrid. Rounds 1 and 2 run online; the Grand Finale is a 24-hour on-site event in Limerick.
Grand Finale	Saturday 20 to Sunday 21 February 2027 (proposed), at a Limerick venue to be agreed: for example a higher-education campus or a summit partner's premises.
Link to the summit	Winning and special-award teams show their projects at the summit on Thursday 25 February 2027 and pitch on its main stage, and attendees vote for an SME Choice award. Stage time and space are subject to the organisers' agreement.
Plan B format	If overnight use of the finale venue is not approved: two days without an overnight stay (Saturday 09:00–21:00 and Sunday 08:00–17:00), with the same rounds and judging.

4.2 The Trust Triad: one baseline for every project

The Trust Triad is the hackathon's signature feature. It is not a separate track. Every project in every track is expected to show three baseline qualities. Together they are worth 10% of the finale score and are the basis for three special awards.



Pillar	Minimum expectation	Evidence on the Trust Card
Secure	No secrets (passwords, API keys) committed to the repository; authentication wherever personal data is handled; the three most likely threats identified and mitigated.	Top-three threats and mitigations; confirmation that secret scanning was switched on.
Responsible	Data used lawfully and within its licence; personal data kept to a minimum (GDPR); AI use disclosed and its limits stated; a human stays in control of important decisions; basic accessibility for user interfaces (WCAG 2.2 level AA where practical).	Data sources and licences; AI-use statement; where a person reviews or approves; accessibility checks carried out; known limitations.
Efficient	Models and infrastructure sized to the problem; no needless compute; the automation fails safely if one component fails.	Reason for the model and infrastructure choices; optional energy estimate (for example with the open-source CodeCarbon tool); a note on single points of failure.

Trust Card: one page, six questions

1. **Data:** What data do you use, where is it from, what licence applies, and does it include personal data?
2. **AI:** Where does the product use AI, and which AI tools did you use to build it?
3. **Risks:** What are your top three security, privacy or misuse risks, and how have you reduced them?
4. **Accessibility:** What accessibility checks have you done?
5. **Efficiency and resilience:** Why did you choose this model or infrastructure, and what happens if one part fails?
6. **Limits:** What does the prototype not do yet, and what is mocked or simulated?

5. Challenge tracks

Tracks 1 to 10 follow the ten automation areas on the summit website, and Track 11 is open. The example problem statements show the intended level; final statements will be written with mentors and SMEs and checked for data availability before they are published on Monday 11 January 2027.

#	Track	Example problem statements	Open data, tools and standards
1	Business processes and administration	Turn a paper- or email-based process (quotes, timesheets, staff onboarding) into a tracked workflow with an audit trail; extract data from forms into a spreadsheet, with a human check.	Node-RED; Tesseract OCR; Python
2	AI and intelligent assistants	An assistant that answers staff or customer questions from the business's own documents and cites its sources; a guarded AI agent that drafts routine replies for a person to approve.	OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications; EU AI Act transparency duties
3	Sales and marketing	Lead capture and follow-up that respects GDPR consent; a content assistant that drafts posts for human review.	GDPR consent rules
4	Customer service and communications	Triage for a shared inbox or web chat with suggested replies; appointment booking and reminders for a small service business.	WCAG 2.2 for customer-facing interfaces

#	Track	Example problem statements	Open data, tools and standards
5	Finance and reporting	Invoice and receipt capture with categorisation and a human check; an automated monthly cash-flow summary from bank exports.	Tesseract OCR; synthetic or sample data only
6	Cybersecurity and compliance	A cyber-hygiene checker for a micro-business (MFA, backups, updates); phishing awareness tools; a GDPR records-of-processing helper; a post-quantum readiness inventory (advanced).	OWASP; MITRE ATT&CK; NIST post-quantum standards
7	Websites, platforms and system integrations	An accessibility checker for small online shops (European Accessibility Act); a connector that keeps web-shop orders and stock records in step and alerts on failure.	WCAG 2.2; National Disability Authority guidance
8	Data management and decision-making	A dashboard built from a firm's existing spreadsheets; a data-quality checker that flags duplicates and gaps; local market insight from public statistics.	data.gov.ie; CSO open data (PxStat)
9	Workforce productivity	Rota and shift optimisation; turning meeting notes into tracked actions; an onboarding checklist assistant.	Google OR-Tools; Python
10	Startup and business operations	Stock and supplier reorder automation; a back office for a new start-up (invoicing, contacts, tasks) built from open-source tools; energy-use monitoring for a small premises.	Open-source business tools; data.gov.ie
11	Open track	Any automation idea that helps SMEs or the wider community, including an optional challenge from the summit's charity partner if it agrees. The Trust Triad still applies.	Any lawful open data

SME Challenge Bank

Local businesses are invited, through the summit's community and channels, to submit a real problem they would like automated. Each one is checked for scope, data and confidentiality, tagged to one of the 11 tracks, and published with the other problem statements on 11 January 2027.

Teams that choose an SME challenge get a short call with that business during Round 2. Teams keep their IP (section 9.3), and any follow-up between a team and the business after the summit is for them to agree.

- **Track awards:** a track award is given only if at least three finalist teams compete in that track. Otherwise the track joins the general ranking, so no track is won by default.

6. Rounds, format and timeline

6.1 Round 1: idea submission (online)

- Registration opens **Monday 7 December 2026** with the 11 tracks, so teams can form and start thinking over the break. Full problem statements and SME challenges are published on **Monday 11 January 2027**.
- Round 1 closes **Friday 22 January 2027 at 17:00 (Irish time)**.

- Deliverable: an idea deck of **no more than 6 slides including the title slide**, in PPTX or PDF, up to 10 MB, named TeamName_Institution_TeamID_Round1. Guidelines are in Appendix A, and a template is supplied.
- Judging: five criteria at 20% each. Two screening judges score each deck; a third scores it if the first two differ by more than 20 points.
- Outcome: up to 40 teams shortlisted, announced **Friday 29 January 2027**.

6.2 Round 2: mentored build sprint (online)

- Runs **Tuesday 2 to Tuesday 9 February 2027 (12:00)**, starting after the St Brigid's Day bank holiday (Monday 1 February).
- Each shortlisted team has one 20-minute online mentor session, and teams working on an SME challenge also get a short call with that business.
- Deliverables: a 3-minute video (problem, architecture and an early proof of concept or clickable prototype), an architecture diagram, a draft Trust Card and the repository link.
- Why it is included: it tests feasibility before anyone travels, gives teams early feedback, and screens out teams with only an idea, which reduces no-shows at the finale.
- Outcome: 20 to 25 finalist teams plus a waitlist of 5, announced **Friday 12 February 2027**. Teams confirm within 48 hours or their place passes to the waitlist.

6.3 Grand Finale: 24 hours on site

- **Saturday 20 to Sunday 21 February 2027** (proposed).
- **Declared baseline:** teams continue from their Round 2 repository. At kick-off each team tags its repository "finale-start", so judges can see what was built on site. Any other existing code, templates or libraries must be declared.
- Mentor rounds and checkpoints at fixed times, two short workshops, an optional overnight mini-CTF, and a single hard deadline at H+24.
- **Summit showcase:** the winning and special-award teams present at the summit on **Thursday 25 February 2027** (section 7.2).

6.4 Master timeline

T0 is the first day of the Grand Finale, Saturday 20 February 2027. December is kept light because of semester 1 exams and the holidays.

Date	T	Milestone	Lead workstream
By Fri 27 Nov 2026	T-85	Organisers decide on the proposal; core team formed; finale venue on hold.	Organisers; Volunteer Coordinator
Mon 30 Nov – Fri 4 Dec 2026	T-82 to T-78	SME Challenge Bank call sent through the summit's community; mentors and judges invited; rules, code of conduct, privacy notice and IP terms drafted; registration platform tested.	Challenges and content; Mentors and judging; Data protection
Mon 7 Dec 2026	T-75	Registration opens with the 11 tracks; outreach starts with Mid West institutions and then goes national.	Registration; Marketing
Mid Dec 2026 – early Jan 2027		Exams and holidays. Registration stays open; SME challenges are reviewed.	Challenges and content
Mon 11 Jan 2027	T-40	Problem statements and SME challenges published.	Challenges and content

Date	T	Milestone	Lead workstream
Wed 13 Jan 2027	T-38	Online information session and team-formation mixer.	Registration
Fri 22 Jan 2027	T-29	Round 1 closes at 17:00.	Registration
Fri 29 Jan 2027	T-22	Shortlist announced; finale venue and catering confirmed.	Mentors and judging; Hospitality
Tue 2 – Tue 9 Feb 2027	T-18 to T-11	Round 2 build sprint, mentor sessions and SME calls.	Mentors and judging
Fri 12 Feb 2027	T-8	Finalists announced; 48-hour confirmation; waitlist active; summit-day attendance confirmed; volunteer training session 1.	Registration; Safety and volunteers
Mon 15 – Fri 19 Feb 2027	T-5 to T-1	Final week: reconfirm judges, mentors and suppliers; rehearse registration, A/V and the submission platform; Wi-Fi load test; volunteer briefing; venue set-up.	All
Sat 20 – Sun 21 Feb 2027	T0	Grand Finale.	All
Wed 24 Feb 2027	T+4	Feedback forms sent; venue handover; showcase materials ready.	Registration; Marketing
Thu 25 Feb 2027	T+5	Limerick IT Summit 2027: winners' showcase, SME Choice voting and awards on the main stage.	Volunteer Coordinator; Marketing
By Fri 5 Mar 2027	T+13	Certificates issued; results and highlights published.	Registration; Marketing
By Wed 24 Mar 2027	T+32	Final hackathon report to the organisers; partner report; lessons-learned review.	Volunteer Coordinator
March – April 2027		Six-week build-on sprint for winning and selected teams, including follow-up with interested SMEs.	Mentors and judging

7. Grand Finale run-of-show and summit day

7.1 Grand Finale

Hacking starts mid-morning because teams arrive with a shortlisted idea and a Round 2 prototype. The opening is short and practical.

Time	Saturday 20 February 2027
07:30	Check-in: ID check, lanyards (including a "no photos" lanyard option), Wi-Fi and platform access
09:00	Opening: welcome, the summit theme and the Trust Triad, partners, rules, code of conduct and judging criteria
10:00	Orientation: problem-statement Q&A, introduction of mentors, helpdesk and channels; teams tag their repositories "finale-start"
11:00	Hacking starts (H+0)

Time	Saturday 20 February 2027
13:00	Lunch
14:00	Lightning workshop 1 (30 minutes): securing LLM apps, based on the OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications
15:00	Mentor round 1 and checkpoint 1: scope locked
18:00	Lightning workshop 2 (30 minutes): accessible interfaces with WCAG 2.2
19:00	Dinner
21:00	Mentor round 2 and checkpoint 2: core flow working; backup demo video recorded
23:30	Late-night snacks
00:00	Mini-CTF (90 minutes, optional, beginner-friendly, hosted on the open-source CTFd platform)

Time	Sunday 21 February 2027
01:30 – 06:30	Overnight build. Helpdesk, first aid and security on duty; quiet room and rest area open
07:00	Breakfast
08:00	Mentor round 3: demo rehearsal
10:00	Submission portal opens
11:00	Code freeze and hard deadline (H+24): repository, deck, Trust Card and backup demo video
11:00 – 12:00	Submission checks (commit history, AI-use statement, completeness); judge briefing and calibration
12:00	Lunch
12:45 – 14:30	Panel judging: three panels in parallel, about 8 teams each; 7-minute pitch and demo plus 5 minutes of Q&A
14:45	Project expo and People’s Choice voting; panels confirm their top two teams
15:30 – 16:30	Final round: the top 6 teams present to the final panel
16:30	Final deliberation (expo continues)
17:00	Closing: results, certificates, thanks to mentors, judges and volunteers, group photo. Awards are presented at the summit.
18:00	Finale closes; check-out and venue handover

7.2 Summit day showcase: Thursday 25 February 2027

The summit’s own programme sets the times. The hackathon needs three things from it, to be agreed with the organisers: showcase tables, a short main-stage slot and a simple way for attendees to vote.

When	What happens
Before doors open	Showcase tables set up for the winning and special-award teams (about 8 to 10 tables), each with a poster and QR codes for the demo, repository and Trust Card
Exhibition and networking breaks	Teams demo to SME owners and other attendees; SME Choice voting by QR code
Main-stage slot (time agreed with the organisers)	Three-minute pitches from the overall winners; awards, including the SME Choice award; thanks to partners and to the SMEs who set challenges
After the summit	Introductions between teams and interested SMEs for pilots, internships or further development

Finalists hear about summit day when they are shortlisted, and they are given letters for their institutions to support attendance on a weekday. If a winning team cannot attend, its recorded pitch is played instead.

8. Judging and awards

8.1 Panels

- **Screening (Rounds 1 and 2):** academics, industry engineers and alumni, with two judges per submission.
- **Finale panels:** three panels of three judges (an industry engineer, an academic and an SME owner or founder). Across the three panels there is at least one security or responsible-AI specialist. Reserve judges are confirmed in advance.
- **Final panel:** five judges: an SME owner from the summit community, a technology-company leader, a start-up founder, an academic, and a security or AI-governance practitioner.

8.2 Rubric

Criterion	Rounds 1 and 2	Finale	What judges look for
Innovation and creativity	20%	20%	How original the idea is compared with existing tools
Feasibility	20%	15%	Real-world applicability for an SME, data availability and adoption barriers
Technical depth and quality	20%	25%	A working demo, sound architecture, code quality, and what was built on site (quality, not quantity)
Impact	20%	15%	Time saved or value created for SMEs or the community, and ability to scale
Presentation and teamwork	20%	15%	Clarity, Q&A, and whether every member can explain their part
Trust Triad (secure, responsible, efficient)	Covered on slide 6 of the idea deck	10%	Evidence on the Trust Card
Total	100%	100%	

8.3 Scoring practice

- **Anchored scale:** each criterion is scored 1 to 5 against written descriptors and then weighted. This is quicker and more consistent than marking out of 100.
- **Calibration:** before scoring starts, all judges score one sample pitch video together and talk through their differences, so harsh and lenient judges become more consistent.
- **Fair progression:** the top two teams from each parallel panel go through to the final round. Teams are never ranked across panels whose judges differ.
- **Conflict of interest:** judges declare any links to teams or institutions and do not score those teams.
- **Tie-breakers:** the higher technical depth and quality score wins, then the higher impact score, then a vote of the final panel.
- **Appeals:** a written appeal can be made within 30 minutes of results. A named appeals panel (an organiser and one judge with no conflict) decides within 60 minutes, and its decision is final.

8.4 Awards

Award	Basis
Overall winner, first runner-up and second runner-up	Final panel; announced at the finale, presented at the summit
Track awards	Only for tracks with at least three finalist teams
SME Choice award	Votes from SME owners and other attendees at the summit showcase
Best Trustworthy AI	Strongest responsible-AI evidence (Trust Card and Q&A)
Security-by-Design award	Best threat analysis and security implementation
Green Code award	Best efficiency and resilience choices, with evidence
Inclusive Design award	Best accessibility and inclusive design
People’s Choice	Votes from participants and visitors at the finale expo
Mini-CTF champions	Top scorers in the overnight capture-the-flag

Prizes are agreed with the organisers and partners and announced before Round 1 closes. They can include mentoring, introductions and work-experience opportunities as well as items in kind.

9. Rules, intellectual property and compliance in Ireland

9.1 Core participant rules

- Participants are aged 18 or over and enrolled at a higher-education institution in Ireland. Eligibility is checked with an institutional email address or student ID.
- Teams have 2 to 4 members, and each person can join only one team. Team changes are allowed up to the Round 2 deadline with organiser approval.
- Originality: the work must be the team’s own. Existing code, templates and libraries are allowed only if declared, and open-source licences must be respected.
- Data: open, synthetic or self-collected data only, with consent. SME data is used only with that business’s permission and never leaves the agreed tools.
- One hard deadline with a published grace policy that applies to everyone. If an outage happens, the deadline is extended by the length of the outage and the change is announced to all teams.

- Everyone follows the code of conduct, which is published at registration and repeated at the opening.
- Finalists are asked to keep summit day (Thursday 25 February 2027) free to show their project. Attending is encouraged but is not a condition of winning.

9.2 Declared-AI policy

- **Allowed:** AI coding assistants, chat assistants, and AI models and APIs, within their terms of service.
- **Required:** an “AI Use Statement” in the README listing the tools used and what they were used for. Any AI features in the product are disclosed to its users.
- **Checked:** judges may ask any team member to explain any part of the code. If the team cannot explain its core functionality, its technical depth score is lowered.
- **Not allowed:** passing off another team’s work or an existing project as new work, or using existing code without declaring it. Either can lead to disqualification by the appeals panel.

9.3 Intellectual property

- **Teams keep ownership** of everything they create.
- By entering, teams give the organisers a **non-exclusive licence** to show project names, descriptions, images and demo videos to promote and report on the summit.
- **SME challenges:** a business that sets a challenge gets no rights in the team’s work unless the team agrees separately after the summit. Any confidential information is shared only under terms the team accepts first.
- **Further development is optional:** interested teams are introduced to campus enterprise and incubation supports after the summit (section 14).
- The final wording should be reviewed by a legal adviser, and by the finale host institution if it has its own IP policy for students.

9.4 Organiser compliance checklist

Area	Action	Owner
Data protection (GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018)	Privacy notice at registration; collect only what is needed; access limited to named organisers using multi-factor authentication; delete participant data 12 months after the summit unless people opt in to an alumni list.	Data protection and accessibility lead
Photos and video	Consent captured at registration; a “no photos” lanyard colour; photographer and social-media volunteers briefed.	Marketing and PR
Code of conduct and safeguarding	Published anti-harassment code; named contacts; a reporting form; women volunteers on the overnight shift; 18+ only. If under-18s are ever admitted: parental consent, child-safeguarding obligations and Garda vetting of volunteers.	Safety and volunteers
Accessibility	Step-free venue and accessible toilets; captions for stage sessions where possible; a quiet room; access and dietary needs asked at registration.	Data protection and accessibility lead
Food	The caterer provides information on the 14 regulated allergens (EU Regulation 1169/2011); vegetarian, vegan, halal and gluten-free options; water stations.	Hospitality and logistics
Insurance and venue	Confirm public-liability cover with the finale venue; written approval for overnight use; security staff; fire-safety briefing.	Organisers

Area	Action	Owner
Alcohol	Alcohol-free hackathon.	Organisers
Partner credentials	Any cloud credits or API keys are issued per team with usage caps and expiry dates, and revoked after the finale.	Technical and platforms
Weather and travel	Monitor Met Éireann weather warnings and transport notices. Decide 24 hours ahead whether to switch to an online finale if a Status Red warning is issued.	Organisers

10. Organisation, workstreams and volunteers

The summit organisers hold approvals and final decisions. The Volunteer Coordinator runs the hackathon workstreams day to day, recruits and trains volunteers, chairs a weekly stand-up (daily in the final week), links the hackathon volunteers with the summit's own team, and escalates issues to the organisers.

Workstream	Responsible for
Summit organisers	Approvals, decisions, partner relationships, escalation
Volunteer Coordinator (Mohit Behl)	Coordinating all workstreams, volunteer recruitment and training, shift rota, stand-ups, run-of-show, and the summit-day showcase
Registration and participants	Platform, screening, communications, check-in, participant handbook
Technical and platforms	Internet, power, platforms, helpdesk, submissions, A/V, partner credentials
Mentors and judging	Selection, rubric, calibration, schedule, scoring, Round 2 mentor sessions
Partners and prizes	Partner support in kind, prizes, SME contacts, partner report
Hospitality and logistics	Food, finale venue, guests, travel information
Marketing and PR	Outreach to every institution, social media, photography, summit-day materials
Safety and volunteers	Security, first aid, conduct, overnight shift
Challenges and content	Problem statements, SME Challenge Bank, workshops, mini-CTF
Data protection and accessibility	Privacy notice, consent, data-protection checks, accessibility
Event operations room	Live tracker for check-in, mentor queue, incidents and timings; incident log; on-duty incident lead for each shift

10.1 Finale volunteer rota (planning estimate)

Role	Per day shift	Overnight shift
Registration desk	4	0
Helpdesk and technical	3	2
Mentor queue and runners	2	1
Hospitality	3	1

Role	Per day shift	Overnight shift
Safety and first aid (trained)	2	2
Photography and social media	1	0
Operations room	1	1
Total on duty	16	7

Allowing for rest breaks and three shifts, recruit about **35 volunteers**. Each shift has a named lead, and at least two women volunteers are on the overnight shift. Training: session 1 at T-8 (roles, code of conduct, safeguarding, data protection) and a venue walk-through at T-1. On summit day, about 6 volunteers run the showcase tables, SME Choice voting and stage logistics, alongside the summit's own team.

11. Resources and partner support

This section lists what the hackathon needs and how it could be provided, mostly in kind through the summit's existing community. Any commercial arrangements with partners stay with the organisers.

Resource	What is needed	How it could be provided
Finale venue	Rooms for the opening, building, mentoring, judging, rest and dining, available overnight	A Limerick higher-education campus or a summit partner's premises
Food and drink	About 155 people at peak (up to 100 finalists, about 35 volunteers, about 15 mentors and judges, a few guests), 6 meal and snack points	Venue catering or a partner contribution
Internet and power	Bandwidth for every device, a backup line, extension boards, charging points	Venue IT team
A/V	Projectors, microphones, sound; optional live stream	Venue A/V team
Mentors and judges	About 15 people across the weekend, plus screening judges for Rounds 1 and 2	Technology companies, SMEs, academics and alumni from the summit community
SME challenges	At least 10 real problems from local businesses	The summit's mailing list, social channels and exhibitors
Prizes and recognition	Awards for winners and special categories	Partners, in kind (section 8.4)
Print and materials	Lanyards, signage, certificates, showcase posters	Digital certificates where possible to reduce printing
Volunteers	About 35 for the finale and 6 for summit day	Students, alumni and the summit's volunteer community

11.1 Ways partners can take part

- **Mentor or judge:** give a few hours across Round 2 or the finale.
- **Set a challenge:** submit a real problem to the SME Challenge Bank.
- **Run a lightning workshop:** 30 minutes on a practical topic linked to the summit theme.
- **Support the finale in kind:** venue, food, connectivity or prizes.

- **Meet the teams:** visit the showcase on summit day and talk to the teams about internships or projects.

12. Risks and contingency plan

These risks cover the usual event basics and the cloud, AI and cyber issues described in section 3.

Risk	Prevention	Fallback
Internet fails	Backup line; separate event Wi-Fi network; load test in the final week	Hotspots; extend the deadline by the length of the outage and announce it
Power fails	Check the UPS and backup supply with the venue	Spare extension boards and charging points
Submission platform goes down	Test it; open submissions 60 minutes early	Backup by email or shared drive, checked by timestamp
A judge is absent	Confirm reserve judges	Reserve judges or mentors step in
Dispute or complaint	Clear rules; a briefing at the opening	Named appeals panel with a time limit
Medical or safety incident	First-aid cover; emergency numbers displayed	First aid; emergency list; incident log
Late submissions	Countdown announcements	The published grace policy applies to everyone
Cloud or AI API outage, or usage limits, during hacking	Teams cache and mock key services and record a backup demo video by checkpoint 2	Judges accept the recorded demo and a code walk-through, with no penalty for a provider outage
Phishing or scam messages aimed at participants	Publish the official channels; state that organisers never ask for passwords or payment details	Warning posted by the operations room; reports go to the helpdesk
API keys or secrets leaked	Per-team keys with usage caps; secret scanning recommended	Revoke and reissue the keys
Personal-data incident	Minimal data; access controls; multi-factor authentication	Follow the data controller’s breach procedure; GDPR sets a 72-hour deadline for notifying the Data Protection Commission where required
Disputes over AI use or undeclared existing work	Declared-AI policy; “finale-start” repository tag; commit history check	Appeals panel review
Severe weather or transport disruption	Monitor Met Éireann warnings; publish travel information	Switch to an online finale or adjust deadlines
High no-show rate (15 to 30% is common)	Round 2 filters for commitment; 48-hour confirmation	Waitlist of 5 teams
Low registrations from some institutions	Campus ambassadors and student societies at each institution	Targeted outreach in the final week of Round 1
Short January window for Round 1	Registration and tracks open in December; problem statements published on 11 January	Extend Round 1 by up to three days if needed, without moving the finale

Risk	Prevention	Fallback
Winning teams cannot attend the weekday summit	Tell finalists about summit day at shortlisting; letters for their institutions	Play the team's recorded pitch at the showcase

13. Participant journey and communications

Stage	What participants do	What the hackathon provides
Discover and register	Check eligibility, tracks, rules and dates; form a team; register	Website with all dates; FAQ; campus ambassadors; online information session (13 January)
Form a team	Cover the four roles; agree tools and how they will work	Team-formation mixer and matching channel
Round 1	Research the problem; write the 6-slide idea deck	Template and guidelines (Appendix A); office hours on the helpdesk
Shortlist and Round 2	Mentor call; SME call where relevant; 3-minute video; draft Trust Card	Mentor booking; written feedback
Before the finale	Plan travel; pack; set up accounts and repository	Participant handbook: venue, schedule, packing list, Wi-Fi, code of conduct
Finale	Build, attend mentor rounds and checkpoints, rest	Helpdesk; mentor queue; workshops; quiet room and rest area; meals
Judging	Pitch, demo, Q&A	Clear timings; backup demo policy; equipment check
Summit day	Demo to SMEs; winners pitch on the main stage	Showcase table; stage slot; SME Choice voting; letters for institutions
After the summit	Feedback; certificates; keep building	Certificates; results; build-on sprint; SME introductions; alumni community

13.1 Channels

- **Hackathon page on the summit website:** the single source of truth for rules, dates and FAQs.
- **Shared hackathon mailbox:** for official notices and private questions. It is role-based, not a personal address.
- **Community server** (for example Discord): #announcements, #helpdesk, #mentor-queue and #team-formation.
- **Packing list:** laptop, charger, student ID, phone, permitted peripherals, required software and accounts, backup files, and a Type G travel adapter for visiting international students.

14. After the summit: follow-up and success measures

14.1 Follow-up

When	Tasks
By Wed 24 Feb 2027 (T+4)	Feedback forms for participants, mentors, judges and volunteers; attendance records; venue handover; showcase materials ready
Thu 25 Feb 2027 (T+5)	Summit showcase, SME Choice voting and awards
By Fri 5 Mar 2027 (T+13)	Certificates and follow-up email; results, highlights and a news piece for the summit website
By Wed 24 Mar 2027 (T+32)	Final hackathon report to the organisers; partner report on reach and impact; lessons-learned review; recommendations for 2028
March – April 2027	Six-week build-on sprint: fortnightly mentor check-ins for winning and selected teams, and follow-up with SMEs that showed interest at the summit

Pathways after the summit: interested teams are introduced to campus enterprise and incubation supports, and to national entrepreneur programmes such as Enterprise Ireland's New Frontiers, which runs through Technological Universities. Teams are encouraged to publish their code under an open-source licence so SMEs can keep using it.

14.2 Success measures

Targets are proposals for a first edition.

Measure	Proposed target	How it is measured
Finalist attendance compared with confirmations	90% or more	Check-in records
Finalist teams that demo a working prototype	80% or more	Judging records
Institutions represented in Round 1	8 or more	Registration data
Women and non-binary participants	30% or more	Optional, anonymous diversity question
SME challenges in the Challenge Bank	10 or more	Challenge Bank records
Participant satisfaction	Average of 4 out of 5 or higher	Post-event survey
Serious safety or data incidents	Zero	Incident log
Trust Cards completed by finalists	100%	Submission checks
Projects still active after 30 days	25% or more	Repository activity
Teams continuing with an SME (pilot, internship or follow-up) within 3 months	3 or more	Follow-up survey
Partner satisfaction and intention to return	4 out of 5 or higher	Partner survey

15. What we need from the organisers

To keep to the timeline, these decisions are requested by **Friday 27 November 2026**:

1. Endorse the hackathon as a student strand of Limerick IT Summit 2027.
2. Agree showcase tables and a short main-stage slot for the winning teams on Thursday 25 February 2027.
3. Help reach SMEs for the SME Challenge Bank through the summit's community and channels.
4. Introduce existing partners who could provide mentors, judges or support in kind.
5. Agree a finale venue and whether overnight use is possible, or choose the Plan B format.
6. Approve the IP terms and the declared-AI policy, subject to legal review.
7. Approve the 11 tracks and name an owner for each to review problem statements before 11 January 2027.

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Appendix A. Round 1 idea submission guidelines

Overview

In Round 1, teams submit a short presentation that explains the problem, the proposed solution, what makes it unique, its likely impact, and how feasible and trustworthy it is. **Maximum: 6 slides, including the title slide.**

1. Format

- File type: PPTX or PDF only. Use the Limerick IT Summit 2027 template if possible.
- Slide limit: 6 slides including the title slide. Extra slides are not judged.
- Design: clean, simple visuals with bullet points rather than paragraphs. Use diagrams and charts where they help.

2. Slide structure

Slide	Content
1. Title	Team name; member names, year, programme and institution; project or idea name; track number (1–11) and SME challenge ID if you chose one; optional logo or concept image. Do not put phone numbers on slides: contact details are collected securely in the registration form.
2. Problem statement	A clear definition of the problem; who it affects; why it matters; supporting facts, with sources.
3. Proposed solution	The idea in simple terms; how it automates or improves the work; key features; basic technology stack or approach.
4. Innovation and uniqueness	How it differs from existing tools; technical, creative or business innovations.
5. Impact and target users	Who benefits; time saved or value created; how you would measure success.
6. Feasibility and trust	Data sources and licences; AI use (in the product and in building it); top risks for security, privacy or misuse and how you will reduce them; what you will build in Round 2.

3. File naming

TeamName_Institution_TeamID_Round1

4. Submission

- Deadline: Friday 22 January 2027 at 17:00 (Irish time).
- Method: upload through the registration platform. File size limit: 10 MB.

5. Evaluation criteria (each 20%)

- Innovation and creativity: how original the idea is.
- Feasibility: real-world applicability for an SME.
- Presentation quality: clarity and structure.
- Technical potential: depth and practicality.
- Impact: value for SMEs or the community.

6. Important notes

- Keep to the slide limit. Slides beyond the sixth are not judged.
- No plagiarism: credit all sources, images and third-party assets.

- AI tools may be used to prepare the deck. Say so on slide 6.
- Write for a mixed jury of SME owners, industry experts and academics.
- Queries: the hackathon mailbox or the #helpdesk channel.

Appendix B. Logistics and infrastructure checklist

Area	Checklist
Venue	Rooms for the opening, building, mentoring, judging, rest, dining and registration; seating plan and signage; washrooms open 24 hours; rest zone; quiet room; step-free access; written approval for overnight use
Internet and power	Bandwidth for every device plus a backup line; a separate event Wi-Fi network for guests; extension boards, charging points and backup power; Type G adapters at the helpdesk
Equipment	Projectors, microphones, sound, cameras; partner credentials issued per team with usage caps and expiry
Platforms	Submission platform tested; channels for announcements, questions and mentor requests; multi-factor authentication on organiser accounts; least-privilege access to participant data
Food and guests	Meals, late-night snacks and drinking water; dietary needs and allergen information; guest hospitality; late-night transport information
Print and materials	ID lanyards with a “no photos” option, signage, digital certificates, score sheets, showcase posters with QR codes
Safety	First aid, nearest hospital and emergency numbers displayed; marked exits and extinguishers; ID-based entry log; overnight security; lost and found; weather check 24 hours ahead; incident log
Final week	Reconfirm everyone; rehearse registration, A/V, Wi-Fi and the submission platform; brief volunteers; prepare the run-of-show, contact sheet and contingency kit; calibration video for judges; phishing warning to all finalists
Summit day	Showcase tables, power and Wi-Fi for demos; posters; voting QR code; stage running order agreed with the organisers

Appendix C. Sources and verification notes

Facts were checked against these sources on 4 November 2026. Several are secondary reports; regulatory dates in particular should be re-checked against official texts before participant materials are published.

Dates were checked against the 2027 calendar: the summit is on Thursday 25 February 2027, and the St Brigid’s Day bank holiday is Monday 1 February 2027. Institution-specific term and exam dates should be confirmed with the institutions concerned.

Limerick IT Summit

- Summit website (theme, date, venue, audience, goals, automation areas, charity partner; captured 4 November 2026): https://limerickitsummit.ie/

Regulation and policy

- EU AI Act high-risk delay (Digital Omnibus): https://www.jdsupra.com/legalnews/eu-legislators-agree-to-delay-for-high-5617765/

- AI Act Digital Omnibus agreement: https://www.winstontaylor.com/insights/ai-act-rules-on-high-risk-ai-delayed-as-ai-digital-omnibus-agreed
- Ireland referred to CJEU over NIS2: https://www.lawsociety.ie/gazette/top-stories/2026/july/ireland-referred-to-cjeu-over-cyber-bill/
- Government pledge on delayed cyber bill: https://www.lawsociety.ie/gazette/top-stories/2026/october/government-pledge-on-delayed-cyber-bill/
- Cyber Resilience Act reporting (European Commission): https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/cra-reporting
- European Accessibility Act in Ireland (CCPC): https://www.ccpc.ie/business/european-accessibility-act-becomes-law-in-ireland-on-28-june-2025/
- European Accessibility Act (National Disability Authority): https://nda.ie/eaa

Incidents and industry data

- HSE Conti cyber attack, independent review: https://www.hse.ie/eng/services/publications/conti-cyber-attack-on-the-hse-full-report.pdf
- Airport check-in cyber attack, September 2025: https://www.irishtimes.com/world/europe/2025/09/20/cyberattack-disrupts-operations-at-heathrow-and-other-european-airports
- Airport attack confirmed as ransomware: https://therecord.media/europe-airports-delays-ransomware-attack-checkin-systems
- AWS us-east-1 outage post-mortem summary: https://www.infoq.com/news/2025/11/aws-dynamodb-outage-postmortem
- July 2024 faulty update, 8.5 million devices (Microsoft): https://blogs.microsoft.com/blog/2024/07/20/helping-our-customers-through-the-crowdstrike-outage/
- Data centre electricity 2024 (CSO): https://www.cso.ie/en/releasesandpublications/ep/p-dcmec/datacentresmeteredelectricityconsumption2024/keyfindings/
- Data centre electricity 2025 (report on CSO data): https://www.irishexaminer.com/business/companies/arid-41875214.html
- NIST post-quantum standards: https://www.nist.gov/news-events/news/2024/08/nist-releases-first-3-finalized-post-quantum-encryption-standards
- OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications: https://genai.owasp.org/llm-top-10/
- WCAG 2.2: https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/

Data, tools and programmes referenced

- Irish open data portal: https://data.gov.ie/
- Node-RED (open-source flow-based automation): https://nodered.org/
- Tesseract OCR: https://github.com/tesseract-ocr/tesseract
- Google OR-Tools: https://developers.google.com/optimization
- CodeCarbon (energy estimation): https://codecarbon.io/
- CTFd (open-source CTF platform): https://ctfd.io/
- New Frontiers at a Technological University (TUS): https://tus.ie/rdi/innovation-enterprise/programmes/new-frontiers-midlands